2. Prompting

What is Prompting?

A **prompt** is simply the text instruction or question you give to an AI model to get a response.

Prompt Engineering is the art of structuring your instructions clearly so the AI understands your context and delivers exactly what you need on the very first try.

The TRADE Prompting Framework

To move away from generic answers, we use a structured blueprint called the **TRADE** framework. It breaks a great prompt down into five essential building blocks:

- **T – Task (The What):** Clearly state exactly what action you want the AI to perform. Use direct, specific action verbs like *write*, *summarize*, *draft*, *analyze*, *reformat*, or *brainstorm*.
- **R – Role (The Who):** Assign a specific persona or expert identity to the AI. This instantly changes how the AI reasons, behaves, and what vocabulary it grabs (e.g., *acting as a senior software engineer* vs. *a 5th-grade science teacher*).
- **A – Audience (The Whom):** Define exactly who will read or use the final output. Specifying the audience tells the AI how to calibrate its complexity (e.g., *explaining a topic to a complete beginner* vs. *a corporate executive team*).
- **D – Details (The Constraints):** Provide rules, context, and formatting guidelines. This includes structural limits (use a markdown table, bullet points), length boundaries (under 200 words), or a specific tone (witty, professional, urgent).
- **E – Example (The Model):** Provide a sample of what a successful output looks like. This technique is known in AI as **"Few-Shot Prompting."** Showing the AI a pattern ensures it mirrors the exact structure and style you want.

Vague vs. TRADE Prompting

> ❌ **The Vague Prompt:**
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> *"Write an email about saving money."*
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> **Why it struggles:** The AI has no idea who is writing it, who is reading it, how long it should be, or what format to follow. It will likely give you a long, dry, and generic message.

> ✅ **The TRADE Prompt:**
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> - **Role:** "You are a friendly personal finance coach who specializes in helping young adults."
> - **Task:** "Write a short newsletter email sharing 3 quick tips on how to save money on weekly groceries."
> - **Audience:** "The audience is busy college students living on a tight budget."
> - **Details:** "Keep it under 150 words. Use a casual, encouraging tone and format the tips using clear bullet points."
> - **Example:** "Model the formatting like this:
>   - Tip 1: [Catchy Name] – [1-sentence action step]"